

PATHETIC FALLACY

Weather or nature reflecting a character's mood



1 What is it?

Pathetic Fallacy (puh-THET-ik FAL-uh-see)

Pathetic fallacy is when **weather or nature** is used to reflect a character's emotions or the mood of a scene — it's a specific type of personification.

weather/nature = character's mood

2 See it in action

Sadness

Rain hammered the windows the night she left, as if the sky itself was grieving.

Happiness

The sun blazed cheerfully on the morning of their wedding.

Danger ahead

Dark clouds gathered menacingly over the castle before the battle.

Hope

A single beam of light broke through the storm as she made her decision.



Look here!

Check what the **weather is doing** at a key emotional moment in the story — writers rarely mention weather by accident.

FUN FACT

The term was actually invented as a criticism! Victorian critic John Ruskin coined "pathetic fallacy" in 1856 to complain about overly emotional nature writing — but writers loved the technique anyway, and the name stuck.

3 Why writers use it

Pathetic Fallacy helps writers: set the emotional tone of a scene before anything even happens, foreshadow events to come, and let the reader FEEL a mood through the environment rather than being told directly.

It's an especially subtle technique — the reader's mood shifts along with the weather in the story without them always noticing why.

4 Don't mix it up!

Pathetic Fallacy

- Only **weather/nature**
- Reflects a **mood** or emotion
- "The storm raged, matching her fury."

Personification

- ANY non-human thing
- Just gives **human traits**
- "The clock ticked impatiently."



Watch out!

Pathetic fallacy is specifically about **weather and nature mirroring emotion** — if a non-living object (like a chair or a clock) is given human traits instead, that's personification, not pathetic fallacy.



You got this!

Ask whether the weather **matches** the character's mood, or deliberately **contrasts** with it (like sunshine during a sad scene) — both are powerful choices worth analysing.

5 Quick recap

Weather/nature reflects mood

A type of personification

Sets the emotional tone



Good spot!

Try writing two versions of the same short scene — one where the weather matches the character's mood, one where it clashes with it.